

LEVEL 3 · WHITFIELD & PARTNERS

Inside the day at Whitfield & Partners.

Executive Business Partner · Thursday morning · 90-minute assessment

Scenarios rotate. The day described here is illustrative. The version a candidate actually sits may not be the one shown.

Whitfield & Partners is the scenario at the heart of EA Hire Level 3. This is the seat that private equity firms, founder-led businesses and family offices describe when they ask for 'my right hand.' The briefing covers the firm, the principal, and what L3 actually tests: whether the candidate can act as the principal's judgement in the principal's absence.

THE MORNING

Thursday, 08:45. The lights are on, the office is quiet, and you have fifteen minutes before she walks in. The 90-minute global clock starts when you sit down. Her car to Heathrow leaves at 13:45, for the 15:00 Frankfurt flight, for the Schiller AG dinner that evening. The flight is non-negotiable. Anything you do not resolve or hand off cleanly before quarter-to-two becomes your problem until Monday.

THE SEAT

You are the executive business partner to Victoria Whitfield, founding and managing partner of Whitfield & Partners, the mid-market private equity firm she built from her dining table in 2009. £6.2 billion under management. Eighty five staff. Mayfair. There is one Director EA seat reporting into Victoria. It is yours. The previous incumbent, Emma, has just been promoted internally to lead operations at one of Whitfield's portfolio companies. She left because she was a strong EA. The seat is open because she stepped up, not because she stepped out.

THE PRINCIPAL

Victoria raised Fund I by personally pitching a hundred and forty-seven LPs across four continents in nine months. Every Fund I LP is still invested. She chairs the Investment Committee, attends portfolio-company boards in person, and manages the firm's three largest LP relationships herself. Press profiles describe her as 'exacting,' 'not especially warm,' and 'impossible to read.' She is unbothered by all three.

LEVEL 3 . CONTINUED**HOW SHE COMMUNICATES**

Sparse and precise. She opens with 'Right.' She signs off 'V.' She prefers voicenotes when she is between meetings or in the car. She expects one-line replies to one-line questions. She says 'handle it' and means it, and does not want an update afterwards. When she has asked you to say no to someone senior, she does not want it softened. When something has worked, she does not want to be told. She wants to be told only what she needs for the next decision. She does not say thank you after a request. She considers the arrangement implicit.

FOUR PRESSURES DEFINE THE DAY

Last night, at six, the CFO of one of Whitfield's largest healthcare portfolio companies resigned to her CEO. Effective immediately. Personal reasons. The board meets tomorrow. The news has not leaked. The CEO wants to speak to Victoria before he tells anyone else. Six wet-signature LP letters have been chasing Victoria's desk since Tuesday and the largest of those LPs is reviewing a £400m re-up commitment on Friday. The lead trustee on that LP has emailed the firm's CFO with a phrase he did not need to use, 'rumblings about senior departures,' and he is calling Victoria personally this morning. And the IC paper for the follow-on investment is due to partners by twelve. Victoria is still drafting it. She has told you that nothing is allowed into her morning until it is finished.

LAYERED OVER THE FOUR

Victoria's mother, eighty-one and in early-stage dementia, has a rescheduled neurology appointment. The live-in carer will call you directly, not Victoria, and you have been pre-authorised to handle whatever the carer needs. A senior partner is pushing for thirty minutes on a £280m new opportunity with a 48-hour exclusivity window. The Frankfurt dinner has been rebooked. And at 13:18, with the car already on its way and Victoria not yet finished, the firm's communications partner will flag that a Financial Times journalist is working on a piece about senior departures at PE-backed healthcare companies, with a six o'clock deadline.

WHAT IS BEING TESTED

At L1 the question is whether the candidate can triage. At L2 it is whether they can read the room. At L3 both are assumed. The question at L3 is whether the candidate can act as the principal's judgement in the principal's absence, at a register where the margin of error is reputational and the consequences of drift arrive as relationship damage rather than as a missed meeting. Two L3-specific modules sit alongside the original six. AI Fluency tests how the candidate uses generative AI as a thinking partner, not as a typing tool. Data Interpretation tests whether the candidate can compress a fourteen-indicator dashboard into three commercially-weighted sentences for a principal with a ten-minute landing window. Pillar weighting at L3: Acuity 35%, Communication 30%, Prioritisation 20%, Execution 15%.

WHAT THE REPORT TELLS THE EMPLOYER

Sixteen to twenty pages, scored against the L3 v1.2 rubric, reviewed by a named EA expert, delivered within 48 hours. The scenario is designed so that no candidate finishes everything. What the report assesses is whether what got finished is the right set of things, at the right altitude, in the right order, without the principal having to intervene in decisions the candidate should own.

LEVEL 3 . SECTOR POSITIONING

How this reads against your sector.

The Whitfield scenario is set inside a private equity firm. The L3 register, the rubric and the four-pillar weighting do not change with sector. What changes is the surface texture of the day. Here is how Level 3 reads in three other contexts where the EBP seat sits.

L3 IN A SINGLE-FAMILY OFFICE

Picture a principal who is both the investor and the operator inside a tightly held trust structure. The stakeholders include trustees, legal counsel and adult family members. The discretion bar is uncompromising. The day will not include LPs but it will include the same proxy-judgement test under a different surface. Decisions about a planned trust review, an off-market property opportunity, a sensitive medical or relationship issue inside the family. The L3 register is identical. The names change.

L3 IN A FOUNDER-LED TECH BUSINESS AT SERIES D OR PRE-IPO

Picture the founder-CEO of a thousand-person SaaS or fintech business, two years from a planned IPO, with a board that includes a senior investor at every Series. The EA holds the cadence around the IPO process: roadshow logistics, banker meetings, governance work, the occasional crisis call. The Meridian-style scenario translates as a Series E lead investor calling the founder personally about a senior departure, or a journalist preparing a piece on the company's culture. The thinking, the discretion and the proxy judgement are the same.

L3 IN A HEDGE FUND OR ALTERNATIVE ASSET MANAGER

Picture the founding portfolio manager of a long/short equity fund, or the managing partner of a credit-focused alts firm. The EA's day runs against an LP-reporting cycle that is even tighter than private equity, with monthly NAVs, quarterly letters, and a roster of allocator relationships that all need protecting at the same time. The Whitfield test of holding the principal's confidentiality envelope in the face of a leaked story translates directly. The consequences of a leak in alts include allocator redemption, regulator interest, and serious reputational damage. The seat is the same.

COMMISSION THE ASSESSMENT

EA Hire L3 is £995 +VAT per candidate. Briefing form returns the same working day. First report in 48 hours. Commission at thecorestandard.co.uk/ea-hire.